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Rick Beldegreen, a volunteer veterinarian with the Carolina Raptor Center



NELSON KEPLEY/News & Record

Rick Beldegreen releases an American bald eagle on the banks of the Tuckertown Reservoir in Rowan County on Sunday.

Wounded eagle soars

Onlookers whoop, holler at successful release

BY PAUL GARBER
Staff Writer

Rick Beldegreen didn't know what the American bald eagle he held in his hands was going to do.

The eagle had been shot in the wing three months ago, and Beldegreen, a veterinarian, is one of the volunteers at the Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville who helped nurse the injured bird back to health.

It had flown well in a long cage the

bird had taken practice flights in, but now it was time to return him to the wild. Beldegreen had seen other birds nose-dive when caregivers tried to release them, and he didn't want to see that happen to this one.

Beldegreen said his chest was thumping as he prepared to release the eagle shortly before 11 a.m. Sunday. "I was thinking, 'Just keep flying,'" he said.

Standing on a small rocky hill a few feet away from the water, he tossed the bird into the air.

A crowd of about 50 onlookers whooped and hollered as the eagle stretched its roughly 6-foot wingspan and flew north across the shimmering water of the Tuckertown Reservoir.

A few seconds later, the bird banked sharply and flew east, landing in the top of a budding hardwood tree a few hundred yards away on the other side of the reservoir.

One of the onlookers was Marvin

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